



THIS IS EAST BENGAL'S FIRST ISL TITLE AND ITS FIRST NATIONAL LEAGUE TROPHY IN 22 YEARS

decisive in a tightly-contested title race.

Meanwhile, East Bengal gathered momentum midway through the season, particularly following a crucial 2-1 away victory against Chennaiyin FC. East Bengal had only two genuine away fixtures outside Kolkata, and the team won both, the second coming against former champion Mumbai City FC.

After years of instability under changing sponsors and coaches since entering the ISL in 2020, East Bengal appeared to find stability with the arrival of the Emami Group. The investment provided resources that could match some of the enormous backing Mohun Bagan has received since its merger with the now-defunct ATK franchise,

owned primarily by the RP-Sanjiv Goenka Group. The appointment of Oscar Bruzon as head coach in October 2024 triggered the transformation East Bengal supporters had long awaited. The seasoned Spanish tactician engineered a remarkable turnaround by reshaping the squad and creating a balanced blend of Indian and foreign players.

East Bengal's remaining "away" fixtures against Mohun Bagan and Inter Kashi were effectively home games within Kolkata. Inter Kashi's adopted venue, Kishore Bharati Stadium, sits in a traditional East

Bengal stronghold, giving the club what amounted to a home atmosphere for the decisive final-round fixture.

Indian football has long revolved around the rivalry between the two Kolkata giants, a contest shaped by distinct community identities for well over a century.

As the season approached its climax, Mohun Bagan faltered at a crucial stage, drawing three of its final four matches. East Bengal capitalised on those slip-ups and eventually caught up with its historic rival at the top of the table.

The title race turned on the latest edition of the Kolkata derby. Entering the penultimate round level on points, the two old rivals faced each other in a match that would significantly shape the championship battle. The contest ended in a dramatic 1-1 draw. East Bengal broke the deadlock in the 85th minute, only for Mohun Bagan to equalise late in the 90th minute.

Although the result kept both sides level on points, it handed East

Bengal a critical goal-difference advantage that ultimately proved decisive. Both clubs won their final-round matches to finish on 26 points, but East Bengal's superior goal difference secured the silverware. For perhaps the first time in the modern era, Mohun Bagan found itself cast as the pursuer rather than the pacesetter, consigned to second place solely on goal difference. It was also the first time such a tiebreaker proved decisive in determining the championship.

Much of the discussion surrounding the season will focus on the resurgence of East Bengal FC. From the outset, East Bengal and Mohun Bagan established themselves as the principal contenders in a campaign marked by uncertainty and transition.

Unlike previous editions, which traditionally commenced in late September, the league began only in the middle of February. The delayed start significantly disrupted preparations for most clubs, many of whom were unable to conduct proper pre-season training camps. The uncertainty also disrupted squad planning and player retention, forcing clubs such as NorthEast United FC to release key foreign recruits because of the prolonged ambiguity surrounding the league's commencement and structure.

Despite these challenges, several teams mounted competitive campaigns. Mumbai City FC remained a strong contender throughout the season, while Bengaluru FC and Jamshedpur FC also produced commendable performances to finish third, fourth and fifth, respectively, in the final standings.

At the opposite end of the table, Mohammedan Sporting Club endured a disappointing campaign and finished with the wooden spoon. Its last-place finish was historically significant, as Sporting became the first club to be relegated from the ISL following the implementation of the league's revised competitive structure.